CLAIMS:

1. A method for generating profile data indicative of ~~the~~ a time dependence of a time dependent parameter in respect of one or more navigable elements of a navigable network within a geographic area, each navigable element being represented by a segment of an electronic map, the electronic map comprising a plurality of segments representative of the navigable network, wherein the time dependent parameter is a parking related parameter, said method comprising:

obtaining positional data relating to ~~the~~ movement of a plurality of devices along the one or more navigable elements of the navigable network with respect to time, wherein the positional data comprises positional data corresponding to parking space search portions of trips;

obtaining (501), for each one of at least one set of a plurality of different time periods, a relative value of the time dependent parameter associated with each one of a plurality of segments of the electronic map in respect of the time period by analysing the positional data corresponding to parking space search portions of trips;

clustering (502), for the or each set of time periods, the segments into groups of segments based on the relative values of the time dependent parameter obtained for the segments in each time period of the set, wherein, for each of the time periods of the set of time periods, the segments in each group of segments are considered to have similar relative values of the time dependent parameter;

using (503), for each group, relative time dependent parameter data associated with the segments of the group to obtain an aggregate profile indicative of the time dependence of the relative value of the time dependent parameter, the aggregate profile being applicable to each of the segments of the group; and

storing data indicative of the aggregate profile with each segment of the group~~;~~

~~wherein the time dependent parameter is a parking related parameter~~.

2. The method of any preceding claim, wherein the time dependent parameter is a parameter whose time dependence exhibits recurrent behaviour.

3. The method of any preceding claim, wherein the method is carried out for each one of a first set of a plurality of time periods, and for each one of a second set of a plurality of time periods, wherein the time periods of the first and second sets of time periods are recurring time periods within respective longer time periods, wherein the second set of time periods are recurring time periods within a longer time period which is different to a longer time period associated with the time periods of the first set of time periods.

4. The method of any preceding claim, wherein the relative value of the time dependent parameter for each segment in respect of a time period is an average relative value of the time dependent parameter over the time period.

5. The method of any preceding claim, wherein the method comprises obtaining a vector in respect of each segment, the vector having a plurality of components, each component being indicative of the relative value of the time dependent parameter in a respective one of the time periods of one of the sets of a plurality of different time periods.

6. The method of any preceding claim, wherein each time period of the or each set of a plurality of different time periods is a recurring time period.

7. The method of any preceding claim, wherein the step of obtaining the aggregate profile comprises determining a plurality of relative values for the time dependent parameter in respect of a plurality of time periods using relative time dependent parameter data associated with the segments of the group.

8. The method of claim 7, wherein the number of time periods in the plurality of time periods is greater than the number of time periods in the set of time periods used to obtain the relative values of the time dependent parameters for the segments used in identifying the group of segments.

9. The method of any preceding claim, comprising associating data indicative of the aggregate profile in association with each segment of the group.

10. The method of claim 9, further comprising associating each segment of the group with data for use in transforming the profile so as to be indicative of absolute values for the time dependent parameter for the segment, or for transforming a relative value obtained from the profile into an absolute value of the parameter for the segment.

11. The method of claim 9, further comprising transforming the aggregate profile so as to be indicative of absolute values for the parameter for the segment, and associating data indicative of the transformed profile with the segment.

12. The method of claim any preceding claim, wherein the parking related parameter is an expected parking search time or a parking probability.

13. The method of claim 12, further comprising using the parking related parameter data obtained in generating a parking search route or in determining an estimated time to find a parking space.

14. A system for generating profile data indicative of ~~the~~ a time dependence of a time dependent parameter in respect of one or more navigable elements of a navigable network within a geographic area, each navigable element being represented by a segment of an electronic map, the electronic map comprising a plurality of segments representative of the navigable network, wherein the time dependent parameter is a parking related parameter, said system comprising:

means for obtaining positional data relating to ~~the~~ movement of a plurality of devices along the one or more navigable elements of the navigable network with respect to time, wherein the positional data comprises positional data corresponding to parking space search portions of trips;

means for obtaining, for each one of at least one set of a plurality of different time periods, a relative value of the time dependent parameter associated with each one of a plurality of segments of the electronic map in respect of the time period by analysing the positional data corresponding to parking space search portions of trips;

means for clustering, for the or each set of time periods, the segments into groups of segments based on the relative values of the time dependent parameter obtained for the segments, wherein, for each of the time periods of the set of time periods, the segments in each group of segments are considered to have similar relative values of the parameter;

means for using, for each group, relative time dependent parameter data associated with the segments of the group to obtain an aggregate profile indicative of the time dependence of the relative value of the time dependent parameter, the aggregate profile being applicable to each of the segments of the group; and

means for storing data indicative of the aggregate profile with each segment of the group~~; wherein the time dependent parameter is a parking related parameter~~.

15. A computer program product comprising instructions which, when read by a computing device, cause the computing device to operate according to the method of any one of claims 1 to 13.

16. A non-transitory computer readable medium having the computer program product of claim 15 stored thereon.